

William W. Franko

West Virginia University
Department of Political Science
316 Woodburn Hall
Morgantown, WV 26506

Phone: (304) 554-9838
Email: william.franko@mail.wvu.edu
Homepage: williamfranko.com

Academic Positions

Director of Graduate Studies, Political Science, West Virginia University, 2022-present.

Associate Professor of Political Science, West Virginia University, 2020-present.

Assistant Professor of Political Science, West Virginia University, 2016-2020.

Assistant Professor of Political Science, Auburn University, 2012-2016.

Education

Ph.D. Political Science, University of Iowa, 2012.

M.A. Political Science, Kent State University, 2007.

B.A. Political Science, Kent State University, 2004.

Research and Teaching Interests

Political and economic inequality; class politics; American politics; state and local politics; public policy (taxation, redistribution, and technology use and access); political participation; public opinion; elections and representation; and political methodology.

Books

Franko, William W. and Christopher Witko. 2017. *The New Economic Populism: How States Respond to Economic Inequality*. Oxford University Press.

Winner of the 2018 Virginia Gray Best Book Award (APSA State Politics and Policy Section)

Mossberger, Karen, Caroline Tolbert, and William W. Franko. 2012. *Digital Cities: The Internet and the Geography of Opportunity*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.

Refereed Articles

Chen, Wendy, William W. Franko, and Robert J. McGrath. 2025. “Occupational Licensing and Income Inequality in the States.” *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management* 44(4): 1374-1393.

Franko, William W. and Julianna Pacheco. 2025. “Despair and Voter Turnout in the United States.” *Journal of Health Politics, Policy and Law* 50(3): 337–370.

Franko, William W. and Christopher Witko. 2023. “Unions, Class Identification and Policy Attitudes.” *The Journal of Politics* 85(2): 553-567.

Franko, William W. and Christopher Witko. 2023. “Class, Policy Attitudes and U.S. Presidential Voting in the Post-Industrial Era: The Importance of Issue Salience.” *Political Research Quarterly* 76(2): 882–898.

Franko, William W. and Avery Livingston. 2022. “Economic Segregation and Public Support for Redistribution.” *The Social Science Journal* 59(3): 375-393.

Franko, William W. 2021. “How State Responses to Economic Crisis Shape Income Inequality and Financial Well-Being.” *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 21(1): 31-54.

Flavin, Patrick and William W. Franko. 2020. “Economic Segregation and Unequal Policy Responsiveness.” *Political Behavior* 42(3): 845-864.

Flavin, Patrick and William W. Franko. 2017. “Government’s Unequal Attentiveness to Citizens’ Political Priorities.” *Policy Studies Journal* 45(4): 659-87.

Franko, William W. 2017. “Understanding Public Perceptions of Growing Economic Inequality.” *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 17(3): 319-348.

Franko, William W. 2016. “Political Context, Government Redistribution, and the Public’s Response to Growing Economic Inequality.” *The Journal of Politics* 78(4): 957-973.

Franko, William W., Nathan J. Kelly, and Christopher Witko. 2016. “Class Bias in Voter Turnout, Representation, and Income Inequality.” *Perspectives on Politics* 14(2): 351-368.

Franko, William W. 2015. “More Equal than We Thought? Using Vote Validation to Better Understand Participation Inequality in the States.” *State Politics & Policy Quarterly* 15(1): 91-114.

Franko, William W., Caroline Tolbert, and Christopher Witko. 2013. "Inequality, Self-Interest and Public Support for 'Robin Hood' Tax Policies." *Political Research Quarterly* 66(4): 923-937.

Franko, William W. 2013. "Political Inequality and State Policy Adoption: Predatory Lending, Children's Health Care, and Minimum Wage." *Poverty & Public Policy* 5(1): 88-114.

Redlawsk, David, Caroline Tolbert, and William W. Franko. 2010. "Voters, Emotions, and Race in 2008: Obama as the First Black President." *Political Research Quarterly* 63(4): 875-889.

MacDonald, Jason and William W. Franko. 2008. "What Moves Partisanship? Migration, State Partisan Environment Change, and Party Identification." *American Politics Research* 36(6): 880-902.

MacDonald, Jason and William W. Franko. 2007. "Bureaucratic Capacity and Bureaucratic Discretion: Does Congress Tie Policy Authority to Performance?" *American Politics Research* 35(6): 790-807.

Book Chapters

Franko, William W., and Christopher Witko. 2024. "Fiscal Policies: Taxes and Spending in the States." In *Politics in the American States: A Comparative Analysis*. CQ Press.

Tolbert, Caroline and William W. Franko. 2014. "State Political Participation: Election Law, Electoral Competition, and Inequality." In *The Oxford Handbook of State and Local Government*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.

Franko, William W. (with David Redlawsk, Caroline Tolbert, and Todd Donovan). 2011. "Participation and Engagement in Caucuses and Primaries." In *Why Iowa? How Caucuses and Sequential Elections Improve the Presidential Nominating Process*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.

Other Writing

"Class Still Matters for Policy Attitudes and Voting, but It's Complicated." September 19, 2023. Franko and Witko.

"Unions Cause People to Identify as Working Class." *3Streams*. September 11, 2023. Franko and Witko.

"Taxes? Start making rich pay their fair share." *Register-Herald*. April 18, 2022.

Review of *The Cash Ceiling: Why Only the Rich Run for Office—and What We Can Do about It*. By Nicholas Carnes. *Political Science Quarterly* 135(1): 157-158, 2020.

Review of *Class Attitudes in America: Sympathy for the Poor, Resentment of the Rich, and Political Implications*. By Spencer Piston. *Perspectives on Politics* 17(1): 265-266, 2019.

“How the U.S. States are Tackling Inequality – and What More Can be Done.” *Scholars Strategy Network Research Brief*. May 4, 2018.

“Income inequality has been growing for decades and Americans are taking note.” *London School of Economics American Politics and Policy Blog*. October 2, 2017.

“Tom Perkins Is Winning: The Rich Already Vote More.” *Talking Point Memo*. February 26, 2014. Franko, Kelly, and Witko.

“How Roadblocks to Voting Make Income Inequality Worse.” *Scholars Strategy Network Research Brief*. January 15, 2014. Franko, Kelly, and Witko.

Grants & Awards

WV Energy Attitudes Survey, 2025–2026. Co-PI with Samuel Workman. West Virginia Office of Energy, \$159,303.

WVU Research and Scholarship Advancement Grant, 2022.

National Science Foundation, Collaborative Research. 2016-2019. “DAPPR: Diffusion Analytics for Public Policy Research.” PI (NSF 1637104) with Frederick J. Boehmke, Bruce A. Desmarais, Jeffrey J. Harden, Robert J. McGrath, Jason H. Windett, and Yu-Ru Lin, \$50,618 to West Virginia University (\$808,129 total).

National Science Foundation, Seed Grant. 2014-2015. “Measuring Skill-Based Technology Inequality in U.S. Counties.” PI (NSF 1338471), \$10,000 to Auburn University (\$499,788 total).

National Science Foundation, Consultant to PIs. 2013-2015. “BCC: Broadband Use Mapping, Data and Evaluation.” NSF 13-519 (\$35,000 awarded).

Auburn Author Award (2013) for *Digital Cities: The Internet and the Geography of Opportunity*.

Best Graduate Student Paper on State Politics and Policy presented at the 2011 American Political Science Association Meeting. “Political Inequality and Non-Decision Making in the States.”

Ballard and Seashore Dissertation Fellowship, 2011-2012.

Professional Presentations

American Political Science Association Meeting: 2009, 2010, 2011, 2012, 2013, 2015, 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024

Midwest Political Science Association Meeting: 2007, 2008, 2009, 2011, 2012, 2013, 2014, 2015, 2017, 2020 (canceled), 2024

Southern Political Science Association Meeting: 2016

State Politics & Policy Conference: 2011, 2013, 2014, 2017, 2019, 2023

Broadband Data Conference, Arizona State University, 2015

Class and Inequality Conference, Claremont Graduate University, 2022

Eastern Sociological Society Annual Conference, 2025

Teaching Experience

Advanced Quantitative Analysis (graduate)

American Government

The American Presidency

Empirical Political Analysis

Introduction to Political Research (graduate)

The Law of Voter Registration and Election Administration (Election Center)

The Legislative Process

The Politics of Economic Inequality (graduate/undergraduate)

Research Apprenticeship Program

Research Methods (graduate)

Research Design and Analysis (graduate)

Senior Capstone

State and Local Government

Professional Service

WEST VIRGINIA UNIVERSITY

Political Science Accelerated Bachelor's + Master's (ABM) program development, 2022-2024

Eberly Associate Dean for Research and Graduate Studies search committee, 2024

Faculty Evaluation Committee, 2021-2023, 2024-2025

Graduate Professionalization Committee, 2019-present

Graduate Admissions Committee, 2018-2019, 2019-present

Developed (with Erik Herron) Elections and Campaigns AoE, February 2020-March 2021

American Politics Comprehensive Exam Committee, 2018-present

Dean Five-Year Review Committee, 2021

Undergraduate Student Advising, 2017-2022

Public Policy Search Committee member, 2019-2020

GEC to GEF transition, 2017

Curriculum Assessment and Mapping Committee, 2017

AUBURN UNIVERSITY

Truman Scholarship Interview Committee, 2014, 2015

MPA Teaching Effectiveness and Assessment Committee, 2014-2015

Alumni Relations and Development Committee, 2014-2015

PhD Curriculum Development Committee, 2014

Rhodes Scholarship Interview Committee, 2014

MPA Curriculum Development Committee, 2014

Graduate Student Evaluation Committee, 2014

American Politics Search Committee member, 2013

Methodology Core Exam Committee member, 2013

OTHER SERVICE

Editorial Board, Journal of Public Policy, 2023-present

Class and Inequality section (APSA) awards committee chair, 2024

State Politics and Policy Section (APSA) membership committee, 2018-2019

State Politics and Policy Conference graduate student poster award committee, 2019

Summer Policy Institute (WV) planning committee, 2018

State Politics and Policy Quarterly Best Paper Award committee, 2014

DISSERTATION COMMITTEE SERVICE

Connolly Baxter, West Virginia University

Adeola Abilawon (ABD), West Virginia University

Mayowa Oluro (ABD), West Virginia University

Cindy Agyemang (ABD), West Virginia University

Trevor Samaha, Ph.D. (2025), West Virginia University

Abdul Uqaily (ABD), West Virginia University

Michael Jones (ABD), West Virginia University

Fatima Nawabdin, Ph.D. (2023), West Virginia University

Liza Gordon, Ph.D. (2021), West Virginia University

John Koehler, Ph.D. (2016), Auburn University

Rebecca Hartley, Ph.D. (2015), Auburn University

John Hall, Ph.D. (2014), Auburn University

JOURNAL REFEREE

American Journal of Political Science; American Political Science Review; American Politics Research; British Journal of Political Science; Electoral Studies; European Journal of Political Economy; European Journal of Political Research; Government and Opposition; Journal of Elections, Public Opinion & Parties; Journal of Health Politics, Policy

and Law; The Journal of Politics; Journal of Public Policy; Labor Studies Journal; Legislative Studies Quarterly; Party Politics; Perspectives on Politics; Political Analysis; Political Behavior; Political Psychology; Political Research Quarterly; Political Science Research and Methods; Political Studies; Polity; Poverty and Public Policy; Public Opinion Quarterly; Publius: The Journal of Federalism; Research and Politics; Social Forces; The Social Science Journal; Social Science Quarterly; Socio-Economic Review; Sociological Quarterly; Sociology Compass; State and Local Government Review; State Politics and Policy Quarterly

Professional Memberships

American Political Science Association

Member of the *Class and Inequality*, *State Politics and Policy*, and *Political Methodology* organized sections

Midwest Political Science Association

Southern Political Science Association

References

Available upon request.

Last updated: February 2026